

Chemicals in the Water

A Chemical Musical

By David Quang Pham

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THANK YOU

Demo Recording 2023

Erick Carter Benzene ☸ Carla Angeline Mongado Vinyl

The Tank 2025

Caitlin Mayernik Producer ☸ Aliyah Curry Director ☸ Grace Shih Music Dir.
 Matthew Ramirez Stage Manager ☸ Fang Tseng Choreographer ☸ My Le Lighting Des.
 Melinda Faylor Sound ☸ Gianna Nepola Costume ☸ Kimi Handa Brown Intimacy
 Erick Carter Benzene ☸ Kammy Wong Vinyl ☸ Mx Hasberry Hydroxyl
 ☸ Joshua Erickson Piano ☸ Tommy Ong Cello ☸ Emerson Cyrus Olson Violin

Underground Skills Exchange 2025

Riley Payne Director ☸ Willow Lautenberg Benzene ☸ Kammy Wong Vinyl
 Joshua Erickson Piano

DAVID QUANG PHAM (he★they)

David Quang Pham is an award-winning composer-playwright and science communicator in Washington Heights, who was awarded a televised front-row seat at the 78th Tony Awards. His musicals include *Ellipses* and *Turnover: A New Leaf*, one acts *Life After* with Marie Incontrera and Stephanie L. Carlin and *Check Out* with Eric Grunin and Valerie Work. David's plays have been produced or developed by *Queer Theatre Kalamazoo*, Musical Theatre Factory, The Tank, Milky Way Theatre Company, Theatre 71, Signature Theatre, New York Public Library, and The Workshop Theater (*The Living Fossils*). His musicals have been staged in Colorado, Georgia, Michigan, and Portugal. He also aspires to be an animation screenwriter, having studied under David N Weiss and Kim Barranté at Sundance Collab. They readapted *Ellipses* and *Turnover* into the animated features, *The Galaxy Family* and *Photosynthesis*. He was the 2024 Great Performances Artist Fellowship Award recipient, 2022 Harriet Tubman Effect Institute composer, 2021 Playwrights Foundation fellow, and 2020 Working Title Playwrights apprentice. His pentatonic music composition blends pop, punk, and Vietnamese folk to create melodies that reflect his Eastern influences. They are under the mentorship of composers *Janelle Lawrence* and *Gonzalo Valencia-Peña*. When not writing songs full of science puns, David plays trombone for Queer Big Apple Corps, Marching Band Casting, and Vietnamese zither with *Mekong NYC*. They hold a B.S. in Astrophysics with honors and minor in theatre from Michigan State University. Be up to lightspeed at [@sciencetheatre](https://www.sciencetheatre.us) or www.sciencetheatre.us

PLOT SUMMARY

Chemicals in the Water is a romantic dark comedy musical where two vagabonds fall in love in the midst of an environmental disaster. This story follows Benzene, a sweet Forest Fire Magazines editor, and Vinyl, a hot-headed songwriter. When their train derails in a river, Benzene and Vinyl must form a toxic relationship in order to survive Mother Nature's wrath.

An eastbound train contains a couple Michiganders: Benzene, an editor needing a break from Midland, and Vinyl, a songwriter looking for their big break in New York City. The train abruptly derails, trapping Benzene and Vinyl in Ohio ("[I Need a Break](#)").

Governor Hydroxyl declares there will be no assistance for the derailment ("[No Agency](#)"). Benzene and Vinyl try to exit the train, only to find they are submerged in the Ohio River. They learn about one another through astrology ("[What's Your Sign?](#)").

Soon, a boat floats by. They take a chance at it. As they paddle with their hands, rainbows emerge out of the water. It turns into a date ("[Chemicals in the Water](#)"). Soon, a bunch of frogs jump them, capsizing the boat.

When Benzene and Vinyl resurface, they face Mother Nature. Mother Nature supposedly leads them to a manmade path out of Ohio. Instead, it is a trap and Mother Nature sends their animalistic goons after them. They fight back the foxes but run off when the eagle is deployed ("[Kick Mother Nature In](#)").

They hide away in Calcutta, seemingly a ghost town. As Vinyl brings in Benzene for a dance, the town folks get out onto the streets. The Chemicals' dance has had a negative effect on them ("[A Toxic Relationship](#)"). They direct Benzene and Vinyl out of Ohio towards the bridge in the east.

They reach the bridge to Pennsylvania. As they cross in the fog, Mother Nature's eagle pushes Benzene off the bridge, mortally wounding them ("[I See Myself With You](#)").

Instead of striking a chord, Vinyl strikes a match and sets the wildlife alight. They comfort Benzene by declaring that love's in the air and that they will be seen ("[Airborne](#)").

Adapting the 2023 Ohio train derailment into a romantic dark comedy, physicist-turned-dramatist and Michigander David Quang Pham interrogates the lack of environmental regulations, city air quality, local/state government redlining, and even Mother Nature with his musical, *Chemicals in the Water*.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

BENZENE, adult, a nature magazine editor of DOW's Forest Fire Magazines from Midland, Michigan. They are a cancer (astrology). Reactive, nature-loving, sweet, and toxic.

VINYL, adult, a PVC guitar-wielding songwriter from Detroit, Michigan. They are a cancer (personality). Reactive, nature-hating, heated, and toxic.

CONDUCTOR, adult, the train conductor (voice only) ///

GOVERNOR **HYDROXYL**, adult, the Governor of Ohio (voice only) ///

MOTHER NATURE, adult, the mother of Nature (voice only)

Optional

PARSLEY & **PYRUS**, characters from David Quang Pham's plant-based musical *Turnover: A New Leaf*, who are now literal plants, singing "**Photosynthesis**" in the wilderness setting (voice only)

☼ Androgyny Chemistry: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

☼ Queer People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of these chemicals; cast accordingly

MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. "**I Need a Break**" Benzene, Vinyl, Conductor
2. "**No Agency (No Further Assistance Needed)**" Hydroxyl, Benzene, Vinyl
3. "**What's Your Sign?**" Benzene, Vinyl
4. "**Chemicals in the Water**" Benzene, Vinyl
5. "**Kick Mother Nature In**" Benzene, Vinyl, Mother Nature
6. "**A Toxic Relationship**" Benzene, Vinyl
7. "**I See Myself With You**" Benzene, Vinyl
8. "**Airborne (Love's in the Air)**" Benzene, Vinyl, Mother Nature

SCENE 1

TRAIN

1. "I NEED A BREAK"

BENZENE and VINYL sit in different areas of the train, passing Ohio.

BENZENE & VINYL

OH NO...

I WILL NOT STOP TO SAY GOODBYE TO THE STATE OF OHIO...

BENZENE

VINYL

I CANNOT WAIT TO JUST END MY CAREER.

I CANNOT WAIT TO JUST START MY CAREER.

I HAVE STATED THIS ENOUGH.

I DO NOT STATE THIS ENOUGH.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

MAGAZINES...

I WILL NOT WRITE FOR YOU NO MORE.

I CANNOT MAKE THESE LONG HOURS.

I WILL NEVER EVER LET THAT BREAK ME.

LIFE WILL NEVER LET THIS BREAK ME.

VINYL shows off their PVC guitar.

VINYL

MUSICIANS...

I AM HONORED TO JOIN YOUR RANKS.

I'M WRITING NEW HITS ON LONG TOURS.

I WILL OPEN UP MY LIFE WITH A BIG BREAK.

LIFE WILL OPEN WITH A BIG BREAK!

BENZENE and VINYL grow aware of one another.

BENZENE

VINYL (CONT'D)

I NEED A FRIGGIN' BREAK.

I EARN A BIGGEST BREAK.

A FUCKING BIG BREAK.

A FRIGGIN' BIG BREAK.

LET ME BREAK IT DOWN FOR YOU:

LET ME BREAK IT DOWN FOR YOU:

I NEED A BREAK!

I'LL GET THE BREAK!

BENZENE joins VINYL's seat.

CONDUCTOR (V.O.)

EMERGENCY BRAKES!

The train destructively derails into a river.

End of "I NEED A BREAK"

BENZENE

VINYL

Y'all need a break.

I will break you!

CONDUCTOR (V.O.)

Thank you, Benzene. Fuck you, Vinyl. I hear you from the front car. Your lyrics moved me more than trains ever could. I need a break. A permanent one. But before I go, here is a message from the Governor of Ohio.

2. "NO AGENCY (NO FURTHER ASSISTANCE NEEDED)"

HYDROXYL (V.O.)

Sorry, not sorry your plans are derailed. The federal government has failed you. They have no agency. Despite that, the local government will not fail you. The EPA, or East Palestine Authorities, will cheer you on. I am Hydroxyl, your esteemed Governor of Ohio. Your godsend.

BENZENE

Hell no.

VINYL

Go to Hell!

HYDROXYL (V.O.)

I do not see any problems.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

Look in the mirror!

HYDROXYL

I'll smash your face into a mirror!

HYDROXYL (V.O.)

I see solutions. Solvents in Ohio. Stay well.

BENZENE & VINYL

We shall poison your well!

HYDROXYL (V.O.)

I'm poised to say... There is no further assistance needed.

The intercom hangs up.

End of "NO AGENCY (NO FURTHER ASSISTANCE NEEDED)"

BENZENE & VINYL

We need you!

HYDROXYL (V.O.)

Tough shit!

The intercom hangs up again.

Awkward silence.

VINYL

That's it! I'm walking.

BENZENE

More like swimming!

VINYL opens the train door to find their train is in the Ohio River.

SCENE 2

OHIO RIVER

VINYL

Oh shit oh.

BENZENE

Ohio River.

VINYL

Fucking dihydrogen monoxides. Always getting into everything.

BENZENE

You're so reactive.

VINYL

Fuck I am. Why aren't you?

BENZENE

It's not in my blood.

VINYL

Well, Chloride is in mine.

BENZENE

Chloride...?

VINYL

You've seen those vans around.

BENZENE

Oh! Are you a *PVC* and the Chlorides employee?

VINYL

I'm a member of the Chloride family, a proud and hardworking supplier for plumbers and electricians everywhere.

BENZENE

How long have you been apprenticing for the family business?

VINYL

No longer am.

BENZENE

How come?

VINYL

Instead of fitting pipes in, I keep busting them out.

VINYL pulls out PVC pipes.

BENZENE

A renaissance Chemical...

VINYL

Pipe down.

VINYL drums with the PVC pipes.

BENZENE

You artists dream pipe dreams.

VINYL

A pipe dream that'll burst into reality soon!

VINYL blows into the PVC pipes.

An EAGLE cries in the distance.

VINYL (CONT'D)

That's a sign...?

BENZENE

What's yours?

VINYL

Excuse me?

BENZENE

You seem like a type.

VINYL

You want me to type it out for you? I'm a...
C2H3Cl...?

BENZENE

Not what I mean. You're certainly not my type.

VINYL

I see through you, flammable C6H6 types. Ya
skin's rubber, ain't far from plastic surgery.

BENZENE

You're one to talk. You need to keep that
musician image. Can I play your PVC guitar?

VINYL

You can play with my pipe.

BENZENE

Ew no. It's probably been somewhere.

VINYL

No shit. It toured all over Wayne County from
the Armageddon Beachparty Lounge to the Olympus
Theater in Menjos Complex, Detroit.

BENZENE

Sure. May I hold your guitar?

VINYL

How bored are you?

BENZENE

Immeasurably.

VINYL

You sound like Dopamine.

BENZENE

Who?

VINYL

Dopamine is a member of the Detroit music scene. They write tons of dopey love songs. It makes that Chemical immeasurable.

BENZENE

You're immeasurable.

VINYL

We sure are not. I'm no Phenethylamine.

BENZENE

Have you written one?

VINYL

What?

BENZENE

A love song?

VINYL

Wouldn't dream of it...

BENZENE

How about a hate song?

VINYL

Now this Chemical's talkin'.

BENZENE

I can sing, too...

VINYL hands the guitar to BENZENE.

VINYL

What do you hate?

BENZENE

(Erratically strumming)

MICHIGAN!

VINYL takes back the guitar.

VINYL

Start small!

BENZENE

Midland.

VINYL

Now, what's your reason for wanting to get out of Midland? *Friend*.

BENZENE

Were you trying to get out of uh...?

VINYL

Detroit. Yes, I'm getting out there. To New York. You?

BENZENE

Oh... Anywhere.

VINYL

OK...

BENZENE

Oklahoma... Definitely not there.

VINYL

The musical I get you there. But, whatcha got against Michigan?

BENZENE

I'm distancing away from my work life.

VINYL

Work and life don't rhyme together. Work and life don't go together.

BENZENE

So, Vinyl, you definitely are a musician.

VINYL

Shut the fuck up. What job didn't strike a chord in you but instead a match?

BENZENE

I was a Forest Fire Magazine editor at [Dow](#).

VINYL

The nature magazine?!

BENZENE

Nature isn't what it seems...

VINYL

Benzene? What is your dream?

BENZENE

To resign to nature. And to get to know you.

3. "WHAT'S YOUR SIGN?"

BENZENE

CAN I GUESS...
WHAT IS YOUR SIGN?

VINYL

OH NOT THIS.

BENZENE

ARE YOU A...
LEO? VIRGO? LIBRA? SCORPIO? SAGITARIUS? CAPRICORN? IN THE AGE
OF AQUARIUS... PISCES? ARIES? TAURUS? GEMINI?

LET ME GUESS...

VINYL

ASTROLOGY IS A DISEASE.

BENZENE

IT NEVER HURT ANYONE.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

SERIOUSLY,
WHAT IS YOUR SIGN?

VINYL

GIVE IT A REST!

VINYL confronts the band.

VINYL (CONT'D)

Seriously, shut the fuck up or I'll give you
all cancer! I'm the musician here!

BENZENE

(to the band)

Pardon my fellow carcinogen. Sorry you're stuck
on this train with us.

(to VINYL)

I'm also a cancer! But, you don't give off
nurturing vibes...

VINYL

Ain't that sump'n.

BENZENE

Cancers are empaths. Well, you sure are
sensitive.

VINYL

AS A CANCER...
I DO NURTURE...
THESE TUNES AND TUMORS
LIKE THEY ARE MY CHILDREN!

NO ONE CAN BEST ME,
NOT ASBESTOS
MY MOON RISING
IS BLOOD PRESSURE
I'M HERE TO KEEP MAKE-A-WISH FOUNDATION IN BUSINESS

BENZENE

CANCERS ARE HOT.
SO FLAMMABLE.
YOUR SUN RISING
LEADS TO FEVERS.
I'D LIKE TO

BENZENE & VINYL

KEEP MAKE-A-WISH FOUNDATION IN BUSINESS!

BENZENE

WHERE IS A SIGN?
DIVINE INTERVENTION!
I HATE BEING STUCK WITH
ANOTHER CANCER

BENZENE & VINYL

GIVE US A SIGN!

An empty boat drifts nearby.

BENZENE & VINYL (CONT'D)

THAT WAS ON TIME!

CANCER'S MY SIGN.
WE ARE CANCER!
WE ARE RISING
TO THE OCCASION!
THE CARCINOGENS ARE NOW BACK AND WE MEAN BUSINESS!

THIS IS OUR SIGN!

End of "WHAT'S YOUR SIGN?"

BENZENE

We, agents of cancer, got ourselves a ride!

VINYL

Agents. Sounds sexy.

BENZENE

After that raft!

BENZENE and VINYL grab the boat.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

I gotta admit: Ohio got some hidden treasures.

VINYL

Hmm... Where does this river lead to?

BENZENE

Water usually leads to civilization!

VINYL

You see paddles anywhere?

BENZENE

We'll let the currents take us.

VINYL

I hate dihydrogen monoxides...

BENZENE

Pipe up!

VINYL

You really trust nature, huh?

BENZENE

With my life.

VINYL

You're such a cancer.

BENZENE

Strum, carcinogen!

SCENE 3

OHIO RIVER

BENZENE and VINYL sit in the boat.

VINYL strums their PVC guitar
before deciding to row with it.

4. "CHEMICALS IN THE WATER"

All sorts of colors project upon
the water and riverbed over time.

BENZENE sees eerie sheens emanate
from the guitar in the water.

VINYL feels something...

BENZENE

THE WATER'S CHEMISTRY...
IT'S GREATER THAN WE CAN EVER IMAGINE.

VINYL
WHILE OUR CHEMISTRY...
IT IS NOT SOMETHING THAT I COULD FATHOM.

BENZENE
THE WATER'S CHEMISTRY...
IT'S SO REACTIVE WITH ALL ITS HYDROGEN.

VINYL
OH, OUR CHEMISTRY...
IT'S REFRESHING TO TELL YOU, MY "FRIEND."

BENZENE
NOTHING'S IN THE WA-

VINYL pulls a dead fish out the
water.

VINYL
WHAT I NEED TO FISH OUT OF MY SOUL...
THIS IS WHAT I NOW NEED YOU TO KNOW:
THE COLORS ARE NOW ALTERING MY BRAIN CHEMISTRY AND MY BELIEFS.
OUR SPECTRUMS ARE ALIGNING.

BENZENE
I CAN'T BELIEVE YOU ARE SAYING THIS-

VINYL
THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING MY HEART **GAY!**

BENZENE winces, thinking "Dafuq?"

BENZENE
JUST HOW GAY?

VINYL
FRIGGIN' GAY!
THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING MY HEART GAY! SO GAY.

BENZENE
ARE YOU OKAY...?

VINYL
NOPE... CAUSE...
THERE'RE CHEMICALS TURNING THE WATER FRIGGIN' GAY!
COLORFUL! JUST FEEL ALL THIS RAINBOW!

VINYL grabs ahold of BENZENE's
hand and have them feel the water.
Naturally, benzene and water don't
mix. So through Vinyl Chloride's
action, BENZENE feels the magic of
water for the first time.

BENZENE

THERE'S WATER IN MY CHEMISTRY...
THERE'S WATER IN ME!

OKAY, I NEED TO GET THIS OFF MY CHEST.
HERE'RE COUPLE GAYS IN THE SAME BOAT.
YOUR QUEERNESS NOW OPENS UP MY MIND TO ALL POSSIBILITIES.
OUR FEELINGS ARE SO IN LINE.

VINYL

I CAN BELIEVE IN LOVE AND SCIENCE!

BENZENE and VINYL pull out
colorful fabric under their boat.
The touch of their hands into the
water causes a ripple rainbow.

BENZENE & VINYL

THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING OUR HEARTS GAY!
FRIGGIN' GAY! QUEER WATER!

Audience Engagement: BENZENE and
VINYL could collect water into
bottles labelled "Queer Water" and
toss them to the AUDIENCE.

BENZENE & VINYL (CONT'D)

THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING OUR HEARTS GAY!

Audience Engagement: BENZENE and
VINYL points to what's underneath
the audience's seats. The AUDIENCE
could play with the fake frogs.

BENZENE

FRIGGIN' FROGS!

VINYL

GAY RIPPIIT!

BENZENE & VINYL

THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING OUR HEARTS-

Gay FROGS jump BENZENE and VINYL.

BENZENE

GAY ARSE FROGS!
END OUR RAINBOW.

VINYL

THIS IS SO GAY!
END THIS RAINBOW.

BENZENE & VINYL

LET'S SET THINGS STRAIGHT:

BENZENE

BOAT JUMPING, NOT OKAY.

VINYL
YOU'RE NOT ON THE MENU ON THIS DATE.

BENZENE & VINYL
EVEN IF YOU FROGS ARE GAY!

THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING THE FROGS GAY/CRAY!

BENZENE
FRIGGIN' GAY!

VINYL
HOPPIN' MAD!

BENZENE & VINYL
THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THE WATER TURNING OUR HEARTS GAY!
FRIGGIN' GAY!

The boat capsizes.

The FROGS steal VINYL's guitar.

End of "CHEMICALS IN THE WATER"

SCENE 4

BOTTOMLESS OHIO

BENZENE and VINYL land.

BENZENE
So, you've never written a love song...?

VINYL
I said... "Wouldn't dream of it." And are we in
a dream?

BENZENE looks upon the frogs with
the guitar in the distance.

BENZENE
Seems like we are...

VINYL
What a nightmare...

BENZENE
Those gay frogs stole your
guitar!

VINYL (CONT'D)
Those gay frogs stole my
rhythm!

The frogs seem gay (happy).

BENZENE (CONT'D)
Happy to make them frogs gay?

VINYL

They're cute. Can we adopt one?

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

My children are not up for adoption, chemical runoffs!

BENZENE and VINYL sidestep from each other like ashamed crushes.

BENZENE & VINYL

We're not runoffs...

MOTHER NATURE

I'd call you two lovebirds. But, you look like you give lovebirds cancer.

Lovebirds get cancer and die.

VINYL

Expose yourself, invisible bird!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

You're one too many exposures, Chemicals. What are you doing lying around on my turf?

VINYL

So sorry for anyone that does.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Oh, you'll be sorry-

BENZENE

What Vinyl meant to say is that we hate Ohio!

VINYL

It's only natural that you hate it, too.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Mother Natures loves all her children, even Ohio... sometimes. Now, are you here to harm my children?

BENZENE & VINYL

We come in peace.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Explain the rivers of dead children behind you.

A stream of dead fishes is behind.

VINYL

Living fishes are just as alive as dead ones...

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

I have Chemicals to fry.

BENZENE

I don't wanna die...

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

You performed a sin to my children, far worse than death. You turned them **GAY!**

BENZENE & VINYL

FRIGGIN' GAY.

VINYL

Mother Nature, *that's bigoted of you to say.*

BENZENE

Mother Nature? More like...

BENZENE & VINYL

Boomer Nature.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Bigoted?! Begone! You're speaking to Earth's most fabulous diva. I don't need other forces of nature to one up me. What are you two up to?

BENZENE

Nothing toxic.

VINYL

We got off on the wrong track.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

When was the [Chemical Revolution](#) ever on the right track? Since the days of [Faraday](#), your kind have been what's wrong with the world.

BENZENE

That can't be. We're cancers!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Chemicals are literal cancers to planet Earth.

BENZENE

You're right. We're nurturing and intrusive.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Invasive. Yeah, nurturing to the capital.

VINYL

Look, nature. I don't entirely believe in this astrology nonsense.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

I've lost my sense of smell from y'all. I'm losing my sense of time.

VINYL

Four four. Three four. Common time. Cut time.
Seven eight. Twelve eight. Several of them from
Tool's *Tempest*. Six and a half eight in *Schism*-

BENZENE

Not those time- Whatever they are. What time is-

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

It's time to get on home.

BENZENE

I'm not trying to head back
to Michigan.

VINYL

We're trying to...

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Follow the manmade trails that another
cancerous species paved on me.

BENZENE

Oh man...

VINYL

Ohioans made this. Follow my lead again.

BENZENE

See you later, Mother Nature.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

I'm everywhere. I see everywhere. I'll feel
anywhere, capiche?

BENZENE & VINYL

I feel you.

BENZENE and VINYL walk the trails.

SCENE 5

MANMADE TRAILS

OPTIONAL

A parsley and pear plant are
present with a recording of
"Photosynthesis" from David Quang
Pham's plant-based musical
Turnover: A New Leaf.

PARSLEY & PYRUS (V.O.)

PHOTOSYNTHESIS! PHOTOSYNTHESIS!

VINYL

You hear that?

BENZENE

Aww... Parsley and Pyrus are photosynthesizing.

VINYL crushes or kicks away the
parsley and pear.

PARSLEY & PYRUS (V.O.)

(Tormented)

PHOTO- AHHHHHH!

BENZENE

Mother Nature's plant children did nothing!

END OF OPTION

VINYL

Mother Nature has no right to say what our
founding Chemicals fought for in the Chemical
Revolution was wrong.

BENZENE

Were we wrong?

VINYL

For them to gain reactive radical independence
for their valence?

BENZENE

They made compounds where they shouldn't be.

VINYL

They belonged here.

BENZENE

The Chemicals drove out the Naturals.

VINYL

Beat out. The Chemicals beat out the Naturals.

BENZENE

They shouldn't beat them.

VINYL

Then, they should've joined them?

BENZENE

We should've joined them.

A FOX enters.

VINYL

Joined them in the fox holes.

VINYL distances away from the FOX.

BENZENE approaches the FOX in awe.

VINYL distances away from the FOX.

BENZENE approaches the FOX in awe.

BENZENE

Aww... What's your sign?

VINYL

RABV-G.

BENZENE

Gee. Judgmental much? They don't have rabies!

VINYL

Then, join them in *death*.

BENZENE

(to the fox)

Fella. Your silence will not fall on deaf ears.
I am here-

5. "KICK MOTHER NATURE IN"

The FOX attacks BENZENE.

BENZENE

Get them off me! Ah! My atomic structure!

VINYL

Hold still!

BENZENE

They're going for my p-orbital!

VINYL

Anywhere but there! That's where you p-bond!

VINYL whacks the FOX off with a
PVC pipe, killing them.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

These manmade trails are not made for mankind,
but my children. My guardians... defend your
mother!

VINYL wields a second PVC pipe.
They guard BENZENE.

VINYL

Reminds me of mosh pits.

Trickles of FOXES attack VINYL.
But, VINYL bats the FOXES away
with ease.

VINYL (CONT'D)
(Repeating and batting)

Fake!

BENZENE
(Repeating)
MOTHER NATURE...

VINYL (CONT'D)
(Repeating)
I'LL FUCK YOU UP!

The FOXES stops attacking.

VINYL (CONT'D)
Anything *new*?

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)
Deploy all land troops!

The atmosphere turns as orange as
the FOXES.

VINYL swipes about. They get
overrun.

VINYL
There are too many! They're on us!

BENZENE takes a PVC pipe and
fights alongside VINYL.

BENZENE & VINYL
Ionic bond!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)
Ironic response!

The atmosphere phases from orange
to blood orange.

BENZENE
(Repeating)
MOTHER NATURE...

VINYL
(Repeating)
WE'LL FUCK YOU UP!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)
You sank my navy. Stomped my army. But, you
cannot bring down my air force!

An EAGLE soars by.

VINYL hugs BENZENE.

BENZENE
We ain't that kind of bond!

VINYL
We ain't that kind of
Chemicals!

VINYL (CONT'D)
Wait, what...?

The EAGLE cries.

BENZENE & VINYL

We're not airborne chemicals! Ah!

BENZENE and VINYL run about. They
come across a town.

BENZENE

Look! A town!

VINYL

(Reading)

Cal... Calcutta? Ugh.

BENZENE

Calcutta, California, Calgary, Caledonia,
whatever! Run to safe toxicity!

The EAGLE cries.

BENZENE and VINYL run to the town.

End of "KICK MOTHER NATURE IN"

SCENE 6

CALCUTTA

BENZENE and VINYL catch their
breath.

VINYL

Away you go, winged monster!

BENZENE

If only we're as up in the air...

VINYL

I'd rather not go airborne. It was either
riding the train or setting foot on the soil.

BENZENE

Or settling fights. Thanks for letting me play
with your pipe... You should wash the blood off
these.

BENZENE returns the PVC to VINYL.

VINYL

Bloody Hell.

BENZENE

Hell's in Michigan. Where are we?

VINYL

Calcutta, Ohio. Not the Kolkata, India my cousin studied abroad in. They ate amazing food with eight pH.

BENZENE

Let's put Kolkata as our next crash landing destination.

VINYL

We wouldn't be stewing in Calcutta, Ohio if you hadn't poisoned the conductor.

BENZENE

I did no such thing.

VINYL

It's Hell.

BENZENE

You made everything a living Hell!

VINYL

(Positively)

Yes. It's hot. What you did to get us here.

BENZENE

(Unamused)

I get it. We're flammable.

VINYL

We've reached a boiling point.

BENZENE

No, we haven't!

VINYL

Why are we arguing?!

BENZENE

Why were YOU arguing?!

VINYL

I can't help being toxic!

BENZENE

Color me surprised.

VINYL

You're colorless, Benzene.

BENZENE

Speak for yourself, Vinyl Chloride.

VINYL

I never spoke for myself like I do now. And it's because of you, Benzene. And we've been doing a lot of panicking, running, fucking up Boomer Nature, and arguing... I speak my gay heart when I say: **I want to share electrons with you.**

BENZENE

Negative?

VINYL

My electrons are for you.

BENZENE

How do you expect me to let my rings localize?

VINYL

How about you and I pi bond?

BENZENE

How about you pi off?

BENZENE is about to leave.

VINYL

Benzene. Don't my valence electrons mean anything to you?

BENZENE

I'm sorry, Vinyl, I know your pi bond are localized and mine are not but you cannot show up in my orbital and share electrons and expect our chemistry to work out. Chemicals don't synthesize that way.

VINYL

What are the chemical properties needed?

BENZENE

I know my hydrocarbon self ain't your property!

VINYL

I love your properties. I love that your boiling point is 80 degrees Celsius.

BENZENE

Don't make me blush at 42 degrees Fahrenheit melting point.

VINYL

I love that you're somewhat dense. 876 kilograms per cubic meter dense. I love when you make nylon faces whenever you play with my pipe. I love smelling your aromatic perfume. I love dreaming about the gay frogs we'll adopt.

(MORE)

VINYL (CONT'D)

And, I love that you're organic. And it's not because I'll evaporate quickly knowing you're actually insoluble in water... We didn't just fall in the river, I fell in love. I am toxic with you because when you realize you want to contaminate the water supply with someone for the rest of your life you want to start the acid trip to toxicity as soon as possible.

BENZENE

(Conflicted and teary-eyed)

You see, that is just like you, Vinyl Chloride. You spill toxic waste on me, making it impossible for me to not pi bond with you. I will never ever share electrons with you!

6. "A TOXIC RELATIONSHIP"

BENZENE

You're toxic...

BENZENE and VINYL look into one another with profound tension, bordering kissing or killing. They suddenly get in tango with chemistry. They dance in a garden that soon wither. They dance by buildings, where silhouettes of couples occupy. Healthy love is in the air for the CHEMICALS, but they are spreading toxins into the air of mankind.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

CORTISOL...

VINYL

DOPAMINE!

BENZENE grows bored of this dance. VINYL takes notice and switches up to **Apache**. This demonstrates toxicity. They ferociously dance, unphased at the silhouettes of couples growing unstable and arguing inside the buildings, representing toxic relationships.

BENZENE & VINYL

OXYTOCIN... AROMATIC STABILIZATION...

BENZENE and VINYL experience intimacy via chemistry by getting into each other's atomic orbitals and sharing valence electrons.

BENZENE & VINYL (CONT'D)

(Cheers to each other)

TO OUR TOXIC RELATIONSHIP!

Everyone on the production team
coughs with their masks on.

End of "A TOXIC RELATIONSHIP"

BENZENE & VINYL (CONT'D)

There's signs of life...

The atmosphere phases into signs
of mankind.

VINYL

We're bringing out the ghosts in this town.

BENZENE

Holy nuclear winter, there are people here!

VINYL

Calcutta has some strange-looking people.

BENZENE

Well, they don't look too healthy...

Audible sounds of the mob echo.

VINYL

They don't sound too happy either. It's the
most toxic thing of them all.

BENZENE & VINYL

Mankind.

VINYL

They also know all. You're sweet. Tell them
that we're lost.

BENZENE

(to the unseen mankind)

Excuse us, where is the exit?

The mob mumbles their answers.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

Oh out of the state is more than fine.

VINYL

You've been wearing masks for years now, so
another is not going to hurt. Okay, okay. We'll
get out of your hair.

BENZENE

Vinyl, they look like they all lost their hair.

VINYL

Hey now. It's not our fault you're losing your hair, motor control, or sense of self. Don't pit the blame on us!

BENZENE

Blame it on Ohio.

The mob seems disgruntled.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

Oh, they don't seem to like that... Well, we're just here living.

VINYL

No, we're not, Benzene. We're not living in Ohio. People of Calcutta, where is the exit again?

BENZENE & VINYL

Right... East. Ope, excuse us. We'll be on our way. You all are the ones with toxicity in your hearts.

BENZENE and VINYL walk east.

BENZENE & VINYL (CONT'D)

Everyone treats us like we're toxic!

VINYL

I thought their hearts would melt for a romantic comedy gesture. After all, we gave each and everyone of them a 150-degree fever!

BENZENE

Romantic? How funny. We haven't crossed that bridge yet...

SCENE 7

BRIDGE TO PENNSYLVANIA

The bridge is foggy.

VINYL

The bridge to Pennsylvania!

BENZENE nabs the PVC pipes.

BENZENE

It's the Vinyl countdown!

VINYL steals back the PVC pipes.

VINYL

Benzene, you can count on it.

BENZENE

We're going to get out of Ohio?!

VINYL

Out of this shithole.

BENZENE

We have to go through such shitting weather though...

VINYL

No shit, this fog.

BENZENE

The notion of patience, it's virtue.

VINYL

You want to stay another second in Ohio?

BENZENE

We have a ways to go before our atomic structure decays.

VINYL

We will not stay another day, another minute, another second. Today, Benzene, today.

BENZENE

Then, let's go this way...

7. "I SEE MYSELF WITH YOU"

BENZENE and VINYL wander through the foggy bridge.

BENZENE

I CANNOT SEE THROUGH THIS FOG!

VINYL

WELL, I CAN STILL SEE THROUGH YOU!

VINYL playfully runs into the fog, leaving BENZENE all alone.

BENZENE

Free-spirited lovers can be the worst!

VINYL

Speak for yourself. Do not worry because you smell like gas! It's impossible to lose you!

BENZENE

Really, PVC fart? Because you lost me here.

VINYL

No way. We've been together for a moment. But we do need time on our own to see clearly again.

BENZENE

I cannot even see myself...

VINYL

We'll cross this bridge when we get to it.

BENZENE

I am small. I am too small. Too small for light that I cannot see it. I lack the complexity of sight. I am small. I am so small. So small I am always an oversight. I am tiny to this world. I am very small. There is atomic will. Free will in these condensed matters. The fog is nothing.

BENZENE meditates.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

The fog is nothing. I can see through this fog, beyond the murky molecules. I am Benzene. I can feel clearly the cues. Vinyl's cues. I want to adopt gay frogs with you! As many gay frogs as we want! We didn't just fall in the river, we fell in love.

VINYL's guitar echoes.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

I SEE MYSELF WITH...

The fog clears up. They soon see VINYL at the end of the bridge.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

I SEE MYSELF WITH Y-

The EAGLE returns with a cry. They swoop in and push BENZENE off the bridge and onto the grounds below.

END OF "I SEE MYSELF WITH YOU"

SCENE 8

BACKWARD OHIO

VINYL runs down to find BENZENE, lifeless in the soil.

VINYL

Benzene!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

I told ya. Mother Nature knows best.

VINYL

Fuck you, Mother Nature!

VINYL tries to lift up BENZENE,
but BENZENE is too heavy.

VINYL (CONT'D)

Why ya gotta weigh six carbon, hydrogen atoms?!

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

I stopped you on land. I stopped you in water.

VINYL

Our water didn't last...

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

You two are my kidney stones and I'm ready to
relieve myself of you cancers!

VINYL sees two rocks by BENZENE.

VINYL

Our train ride is not over, Mother Nature. Here
is our last stop.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)

Indeed. You're right on track to your end.

VINYL

It's a start. Air is your last chance to be
reborn. I just need to strike a chord. A match.
Long live Benzene and Vinyl...

8. "AIRBORNE (LOVE'S IN THE AIR)"

VINYL hesitantly holds the rocks.

VINYL

REST WARMLY, MY LOVE.
THEY WILL SEE OUR...

BENZENE
(Dying)

LIGHT...

VINYL

LIGHT.

VINYL strums the rocks, which sets
everything ablaze.

The EAGLE burns and falls out of
the sky.

BENZENE is risen.

MOTHER NATURE (V.O.)
(Coughing and choking)

Fwhaoeghwoeanevewoaruwoeirhewaofhoewahfoewhfow.

VINYL

LOVE'S IN THE AIR!

SUCK ON THAT, SUCK ON THESE, MOTHER FUCKING NATURE!
YA BOOMER!

As BENZENE phases into the air,
they use their remaining life
force to tug on VINYL.

BENZENE

LOVE, TO THE AIR?

VINYL accepts BENZENE's orbital.

BENZENE (CONT'D)

WE ARE AIRBORNE!

VINYL

LET'S GET AIRBORNE!

The fire swallows up BENZENE and
VINYL. The two CHEMICALS become
one with the rainbowy air.

Ohio burns down.

BENZENE & VINYL

THERE'RE CHEMICALS IN THIS FIRE MAKING OUR HEARTS GAY!
FRIGGIN' GAY!

BENZENE and VINYL adopt GAY FROGS.
Rainbow-out.

End of "AIRBORNE (LOVE'S IN THE AIR)"

END OF OHIO